

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Periodization and evidence discipline

c. 600 BCE -> second-urbanisation background

c. 200 BCE -> regional polities and wider craft-trade networks

1st-2nd c. CE -> dense urban and maritime evidence in selected regions

3rd c. CE onward -> decline, continuity and route change coexist

SOURCES: texts + inscriptions + coins + craft debris + settlements + imports

RULE: archaeological phase labels do not automatically prove dynastic rule.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Agrarian base of urban growth

LAND + WATER + LABOUR + DIVERSE CROPS

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food surplus + cotton / oilseeds / timber / ores / salt

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supports non-food producers and supplies craft chains

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town demand returns tools, markets, credit and institutions

VERDICT: village and town formed an interdependent system, not separate economies.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Craft production chains

RAW MATERIAL -> SPECIALISED LABOUR -> INSTALLATION / TOOL -> FINISHED GOOD

cotton -> spinning -> weaving -> dyeing -> cloth

agate/carnelian -> cutting -> drilling -> polishing -> beads

ore -> smelting -> forging/casting -> tools and ornaments

clay/glass/ivory/shell -> repeated forms and elite/common consumption

LIMIT: one vat, mould or workshop cannot establish ownership, scale or export destination.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Shreni, nigama and merchant bodies

ARTISANS / MERCHANTS

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shreni / corporate body / nigama identities

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deposits + endowments + standards + representation + donor visibility

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recurring provision for religious institutions

CAUTION: local records show corporate capacity, not one pan-Indian guild law  
or a modern banking system.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Inland corridors and market nodes

NORTH-WEST -> Taxila -> Mathura -> Ujjain -> Bharuch

GANGA ROUTES -> Kaushambi and other urban nodes

DECCAN -> Paithan / Tagara -> western and eastern outlets

TAMILAKAM -> production zones -> chattu caravans -> ports

UTTARAPATHA / DAKSHINAPATHA = broad changing route concepts

RULE: route lines show connectivity, not permanent paved highways or one ruler's monopoly.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Ports, monsoon and Indian Ocean exchange

HINTERLAND SURPLUS -> MARKET NODE -> PORT

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aggregation + customs + storage + shipping + redistribution

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seasonal winds + accumulated navigation knowledge

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Arabian Sea / Red Sea / Bay of Bengal networks

TRAP: no single foreign discoverer created monsoon sailing or Indian maritime trade.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Mediterranean exchange without colony claims

PEPPER / TEXTILES / BEADS / PEARLS / IVORY / STONES OUTWARD

COINS / BULLION / AMPHORAE / GLASS / CERAMICS / METALS INWARD

EVIDENCE -> Periplus, Pliny, papyrus, archaeology and coin contexts

PLINY -> Roman anxiety, not an audited Indian trade balance

IMPORTED OBJECT -> contact and consumption possibility

NOT PROVED -> resident Roman colony, sovereignty or universal prosperity.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Coinage and uneven monetisation

KUSHANA -> gold and copper

WESTERN KSHATRAPA -> silver

SATAVAHANA -> lead, copper, potin and selected silver/portrait issues

CIVIC / PUNCH-MARKED / ROMAN-LINKED FINDS -> varied monetary worlds

COINS aided payments, revenue and exchange.

LIMIT: coin abundance does not erase barter, kind payments or regional monetary gaps.



## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Urban morphology and regional centres

### URBAN INDICATORS

fortification | planned streets | brick | drains | wells | coins | seals | crafts

NORTH-WEST / NORTH: Taxila, Mathura, Kaushambi and other nodes

CENTRAL / WEST: Ujjain, Bharuch and route centres

DECCAN / SOUTH: Paithan, Tagara, Arikamedu, Puhar and others

RULE: infer urban function from a cluster of indicators, never one imported sherd.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Religion, state and urban-rural systems

VILLAGES -> food, fibre, labour and raw materials

TOWNS -> workshops, markets, rulers and consumers

ROUTES / PORTS -> wider demand and movement

RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS -> donors, endowments, lodging and legitimacy

STATE -> security + tolls + coinage + infrastructure + extraction

RESULT: mutually reinforcing functions, but burdens and benefits were unequal.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Transformation and decline debate

OBSERVED: contraction at some sites / coin changes / route shifts

POSSIBLE CAUSES: political fragmentation + demand change + ecology + local restructuring

ROMAN-TRADE DECLINE -> relevant to selected circuits, never a universal single cause

CONTINUITIES: internal, eastern and regional networks; new centres can rise

METHOD: separate one site's decline from subcontinental transformation

VERDICT: early historic urbanism changed unevenly after the second century CE.

## ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: UPSC answer spine

DEFINE PERIOD + SOURCE CAUTION

- > agrarian and raw-material base
- > crafts and corporate institutions
- > inland routes + port-hinterland mechanism
- > money + urban morphology + religious/state roles
- > regional comparison + decline debate

WRITE EACH UNIT: claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit

VERDICT: a networked, mutually reinforcing but regionally uneven florescence.